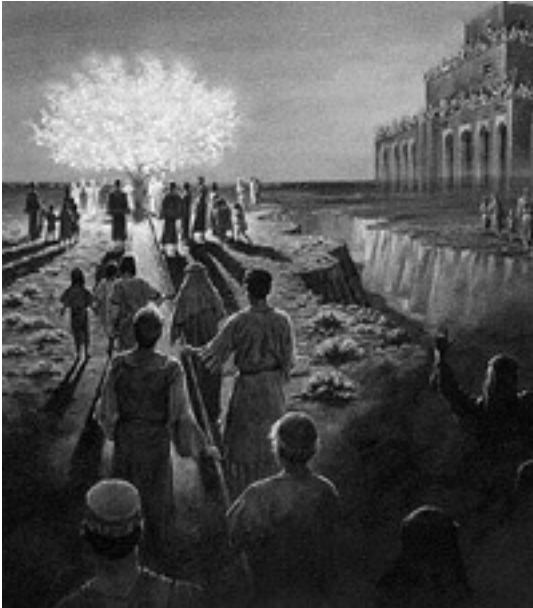


BKM 3 Enrichment



E1. The vision of Joseph Smith, Sr. in 1811 as recorded in Lucy Mack Smith's history compared back and forth with Lehi's vision. Written and compiled by Scot Facer Proctor at Meridian Magazine. See reference and link at the end of this excerpt to read his entire article. I strongly recommend it. I have used "bold" marks to make clearer who is speaking in this format.

"I thought," said [Joseph Smith, Sr.], "I was traveling in an open, desolate field which appeared to be very barren. As I was thus traveling, the thought suddenly came into my mind that I had better stop and reflect upon what I was doing before I went any farther. So I asked myself, 'What motive can I have in traveling here, and what place can this be?'"

Notice in Lehi's vision he says: "methought I saw in my dream, a dark and dreary wilderness."

Joseph Smith, Sr. continues:

"My guide, who was by my side as before, said, 'This is the desolate world, but travel on.' The road was so broad and barren that I wondered why I should travel in it, for, said I to myself, 'Broad is the road, and wide is the gate that leads to death, and many there be that walk therein; but narrow is the way, and strait is the gate that leads to everlasting life, and few there be that go in thereat.'"

Lehi recorded: "And it came to pass that as I followed him [his guide] I beheld myself that I was in a dark and dreary waste. And after I had traveled for the space of many hours in darkness, I began to pray unto the Lord that he would have mercy on me, according to the multitude of his tender mercies."

Joseph Smith, Sr. continued:

"Traveling a short distance further, I came to a narrow path. This path I entered, and, when I had traveled a little way in it, I beheld a beautiful stream of water which ran from the east to the west. Of this stream I could see neither the source nor yet the mouth, but as far as my eyes could extend I could see a rope, running along the bank of it about as high as a man could reach, and beyond me was a low but very pleasant valley in which stood a tree such as I had never seen before. It was exceedingly handsome, insomuch that I looked upon it with wonder and admiration. Its beautiful branches spread themselves somewhat like an umbrella, and it bore a kind of fruit, in shape much like a chestnut bur, and as white as snow, or, if possible, whiter. I gazed upon the same with considerable interest, and as I was doing so, the burs or shells commenced opening and shedding their particles, or the fruit which they contained, which was of dazzling whiteness. I drew near and began to eat of it, and I found it delicious beyond description."

Lehi said of his vision: "And it came to pass that I beheld a tree, whose fruit was desirable to make one happy. And it came to pass that I did go forth and partake of the fruit thereof; and I beheld that it was most sweet, above all that I ever before tasted. Yea, and I beheld that the fruit thereof was white, to exceed all the whiteness that I had ever seen."

Joseph Smith, Sr. recorded:

"As I was eating, I said in my heart, 'I cannot eat this alone, I must bring my wife and children, that they may partake with me.' Accordingly, I went and brought my family, which consisted of a wife and seven children, and we all commenced eating and praising God for this blessing. We were exceedingly happy, insomuch that our joy could not easily be expressed."

Lehi said: "And as I partook of the fruit thereof it filled my soul with exceedingly great joy; wherefore, I began to be desirous that my family should partake of it also; for I knew that it was desirable above all other fruit. And as I cast my eyes round about, that perhaps I might discover my family also..."

Both Lehi and Joseph Smith, Sr. could not partake of the fruit alone, they had to share it with their family and gather their families in to them (remember gathering seed of every kind?).

Joseph Smith, Sr. continued:

"While thus engaged, I beheld a spacious building standing opposite the valley which we were in, and it appeared to reach to the very heavens. It was full of doors and windows, and they were all filled with people, who were very finely dressed. When these people observed us in the low valley, under the tree, they pointed the finger of scorn at us, and treated us with all manner of disrespect and contempt. But their contumely we utterly disregarded."

Lehi's vision was similar: "And I also cast my eyes round about, and beheld, on the other side of the river of

water, a great and spacious building; and it stood as it were in the air, high above the earth. And it was filled with people, both old and young, both male and female; and their manner of dress was exceedingly fine; and they were in the attitude of mocking and pointing their fingers towards those who had come at and were partaking of the fruit.”[i]

Joseph Smith, Sr. was given special instructions to gather his own seed in the vision:

“I presently turned to my guide and inquired of him the meaning of the fruit that was so delicious. He told me it was the pure love of God, shed abroad in the hearts of all those who love him and keep his commandments. He then commanded me to go and bring the rest of my children. I told him that we were all there. ‘No,’ he replied, ‘look yonder, you have two more, and you must bring them also.’ Upon raising my eyes, I saw two small children standing some distance off. I immediately went to them and brought them to the tree, upon which they commenced eating with the rest, and we all rejoiced together. The more we ate, the more we seemed to desire, until we even got down upon our knees and scooped it up, eating it by double handfuls.”

Their joy could not be contained in partaking of the fruit together. **Joseph Smith, Sr. concluded** by asking what the meaning of the building was:

“After feasting in this manner a short time, I asked my guide what was the meaning of the spacious building which I saw. He replied, ‘It is Babylon, it is Babylon, and it must fall. The people in the doors and windows are the inhabitants thereof, who scorn and despise the Saints of God because of their humility.’ I soon awoke, clapping my hands together for joy.”[ii]

Nephi also explained the meaning of the spacious building from his own vision:

“And the multitude of the earth was gathered together; and I beheld that they were in a large and spacious building, like unto the building which my father saw. And the angel of the Lord spake unto me again, saying: Behold the world and the wisdom thereof; yea, behold the house of Israel hath gathered together to fight against the twelve apostles of the Lamb. And it came to pass that I saw and bear record, that the great and spacious building was the pride of the world; and it fell, and the fall thereof was exceedingly great. And the angel of the Lord spake unto me again, saying: Thus shall be the destruction of all nations, kindreds, tongues, and people, that shall fight against the twelve apostles of the Lamb.”[iii]

(Scot Facer Proctor, “[Book of Mormon Extras Lesson 3 —Joseph Smith’s Father Saw the tree of Life 19 Years Before the Book of Mormon was Published](#),” Meridian Magazine, January 7, 2016. [Note: Scot did a beautiful of exploring meanings found in the Book of Mormon, Tree of Life scriptures and in comparing them to Joseph Smith’s father’s dream. I strongly recommend you study the entire article by clicking on the link above.]])

E2. New York City Book Club in 1938: “Brother William E. Berrett gives an account of an interesting gathering in New York City in 1938. It was the **New York City Book Club**. Their speaker was the Honorable Henry A. Wallace, then Secretary of Agriculture. His subject was “[Good Books of the Nineteenth Century](#).” In the course of his remarks he said, “The greatest book published in the nineteenth century in the field of religion was the Book of Mormon. Although this book was read by less than one percent of Americans, it affected that one percent so powerfully as to change the history of the nation.”

Brother Berrett states further, “It is a book that has aroused a storm of protest. It has done what the Prophet Joseph said it would do. It has divided men into two camps—those who are for it and those who are against it. There have [possibly] been more books written against it than against any book ever published in America. ... On the shelves of the Church Library in the Church Office Building there are more than 1,500 [anti-Mormon] books, each of which, in a portion of its pages, makes an attack on the Book of Mormon. Fifteen hundred volumes by fifteen hundred separate authors. Of those fifteen hundred probably only two ever reached a second edition. ...” (William E. Berrett, “What Is the Book of Mormon?” in *Know Your Religion Series* 1953–54, 21 Oct. 1953, pp. 1–2.)

...
[Elder Cullimore related two fascinating stories of the Book of Mormon’s role in converting multiple people.]

“The first is about James Monroe Hastings and his wife, Eddie. Mr. Hastings was a Baptist minister in New Mexico during the depression days of the early 1930s. After one of his revival meetings, someone gave him a Book of Mormon which he took home and placed on the shelf...

...
The other experience was related to me by a good friend. He gave a Book of Mormon to one of his associates in business... When he saw him again, the friend said, “Possibly you’d like to know what happened to your Book of Mormon? I haven’t read it, but many of my family have, and there are now nineteen of my family members in your church as a result of reading it.

“I took the book home and put it on the shelf. One night as my mother was babysitting for us, she saw the book and began to read it. When we came home, she asked us about it. She said, ‘This book is true.’ This started a chain of events that brought about these many baptisms.” (James A. Cullimore (Assistant to the Twelve), “[The Book of Mormon](#),” *Ensign*, May 1976.)

E3. Christ in the Book of Mormon: A story my meeting with the "Reverend" Jones to show him Christ in the Book of Mormon. I was a Chaplain in the Navy at the time.

In the fall of 1983, I graduated from the Navy Chaplain's Basic Course in Newport, Rhode Island. At that time I was not prepared for certain anti-Mormon encounters I was going to experience. My orders directed me to report to the First Marine Division at Camp Pendleton where I was to be assigned to a Marine infantry battalion.

The battalion was located at a remote site called Camp Horno. At a Division staff meeting, the executive officer commented on my assignment, "Ah, Horno, the oven. That's what it means in Spanish you know." Then he smiled as though I would discover "Horno" soon enough.

One week later I was introducing myself to the battalion staff officers and as I made my rounds to get acquainted, each officer asked, "Have you met Reverend Jones yet?"

When I said I had not, they responded, "Don't worry, you will."

A Marine battalion consists of about 750 men divided into five companies. Corporal Jones was assigned to Lima Company and I inquired among the enlisted Marines to learn more about the notable "Reverend" Jones. They told me he was on leave (as was most of the battalion) recovering from the six-month deployment they had just completed the week before. He was a Marine corporal who had been a former drug addict. He had been converted to Christ and relieved of his powerful addiction to drugs with this dramatic shift in his life. Since that time he had become a persuasive lay preacher for Christ. Preaching and testifying of Christ was all he did in his spare time. He was like a kind of mosquito to those who weren't interested in his message (which was most of the battalion), they just brushed him aside. But he had some followers who banded with him to try and reach the others.

I finally met him at the recreation offices two weeks later. He was ironing a uniform for the inspection the next morning. He seemed pleased to see me and asked a few questions about the scriptures. Then he showed me a lesson plan from a Bible class and asked me what I thought about it. I made a comment he seemed to like. Finally, he asked which faith group I belonged to and I told him "Mormon". He did not react negatively to that and seemed to know nothing about our faith. We said little more as he finished ironing his shirt. He said he had to go to a revival at the Eagle's Nest, a prominent place for Evangelical worship and fellowship. Hence our beginning was rather friendly.

He attended all my worship services in the field for about six months until the day he saw a virulent anti-Mormon movie at the Eagle's Nest. From then on he refused to attend my services and sought to persuade others that Mormonism was of the devil.

About a year passed and our battalion boarded three troop carrying assault ships to spend six months in the Pacific. I rode the largest troop transport. It was a giant ship nearly 900 feet long and much like a small aircraft carrier. It carried helicopters and trucks and could transport (with the crew) about 2600 men.

As our tour neared its end, I was re-assigned to a smaller ship for our two-week return trip to Hawaii. This happened to be the ship where "Reverend" Jones was assigned.

During the trip I asked him to attend my services, but he would not. Furthermore he persuaded the ship's protestant lay leader and nearly all the other Protestants on board ship that Mormons weren't Christian. Thus, they wouldn't attend either.

Fortunately, the protestant lay leader let me show him the Book of Mormon to see it for himself. He saw the introduction and many of the verses, which testified powerfully of Christ. After seeing the truth, he decided to support me and convinced a few of the other Protestants to attend my divine services.

Corporal Jones led his own little worship service. I let him use my office for that purpose and even attended his first session, but I prepared to speak with him when he returned the key after the second session.

When he called at my stateroom, I invited him in and said, "I believe the movie you saw doesn't square with the truth. I know Christ is my Savior and have been taught that from my youth. May I ask why you think our faith is of the devil?"

He responded with an objection.

"I don't know the answer," I said, "but I do know that Jesus Christ is my Lord and I know that from the Book of Mormon which was written to bring us to Christ. May I show it to you and let you judge for yourself?"

When he consented, I showed him the translated preface in which I had highlighted: "to the convincing of the Jew and Gentile that JESUS is the CHRIST, the ETERNAL GOD."

It seemed important that he trust what I would tell him about the Book of Mormon, so in terms he knew, I outlined my experience as a Mormon by saying, "I've been a member of many congregations; served as a missionary for two years; graduated from our formal religious training programs; taught innumerable gospel classes and pastored a congregation. I know what is commonly taught in our church. This Book of Mormon (which I cradled in my hands) is our standard for doctrine and I'd like you to see for yourself what it says about Jesus Christ."

With that we sat side by side while I turned to Second Nephi in chapter twenty-five. I let him hear the sincerity in my voice while I read verse 26 with him:

And we talk of Christ, we rejoice in Christ, we preach of Christ, we prophesy of Christ, and we write according to our prophecies, that our children may know to what source they may look for a remission of their sins (2 Nephi 25:26).

I showed him other passages, but finally took him to the last page and told him about Moroni who was the last prophet to write in the Book of Mormon. I noted that Moroni watched the destruction of their civilized nation because they rejected Christ and his teachings. Then I showed him Moroni's final plea.

Yea, come unto Christ, and be perfected in him, and deny yourselves of all ungodliness; that by his grace ye may be perfect in Christ

And again, if ye by the grace of God are perfect in Christ, and deny not his power, then are ye sanctified in Christ by the grace of God, through the shedding of the blood of Christ, which is in the covenant of the Father unto the remission of your sins, that ye become holy, without spot. (Moroni 10:32-33.)

I said, "The Book of Mormon is our scripture. It begins with Christ. It continues with Christ. It ends with Christ. It refers to Christ "more frequently per verse" than even the New Testament. Its record of Christ's visit to America establishes his concern for all people and even its final words call men to him.

I paused and watched while he pondered, staring intently at the scriptures before him.

After a long silence he said, "I guess I'll have to read the Book of Mormon. Do you have another copy?"

That was my last day aboard his ship. As I left the following morning though, he and one of his friends met me on the dock to express their friendship and wish me well. Then they departed for Waikiki. I never saw either of them again, but the marvelous testimonies of Christ found in the Book of Mormon enabled us to part as friends, and they enabled Reverend Jones to see the Book of Mormon in an entirely new light. I also know that the Book of Mormon brought me closer to Christ than I had ever thought possible. The Lord had answered my prayers with divine precision and opened my eyes to see the importance of Christ as I had never seen him before.

Reflecting on the experience again and again, I began to sense the great convincing power of the Book of Mormon. (See Stephen M. Bird, *Prayers That Bring Miracles*, (Murray, Utah: Aspen Books, 1997), 77-83 in the hardcover edition. I have based this version on the pages in my book.)

E4. Additional Teaching Ideas (from Lesson #1)

2. Sharing the Book of Mormon

"Consult with the bishopric and the ward mission leader about how members can obtain copies of the Book of Mormon to share with nonmember friends and acquaintances.

"In class, suggest that a class goal this year should be to share the Book of Mormon with nonmember friends and acquaintances. Explain to class members how they may obtain copies of the Book of Mormon, and encourage each class member to give a copy to at least one friend or acquaintance during the year.

"Several times during the year, as the Spirit directs, ask class members if any of them have yet shared a copy of the Book of Mormon. Invite class members who have done this to briefly describe the experience. Continue to encourage class members to share the Book of Mormon with others." (*Lesson Manual*)

Recommended Reading:

1. Neal Rappleye, "[A New Way to Study and Share the Book of Mormon](#)," Meridian, December 28, 2015. This article introduces a new Book of Mormon Resources website: Book of Mormon Central.
2. [Book of Mormon Central.org](#).
3. [2016 Gospel Doctrine—Recommended Resources on the Book of Mormon \(updated\)](#), Ben S., Times and Seasons, December 19, 2015.
4. "[Complexity, Consistency, Ignorance, and Probabilities](#)," Melvin J. Thorne, *Book of Mormon Authorship: Revisited*, Chapter 7.
5. Scot Facer Proctor, "[Book of Mormon Extras Lesson 3—Joseph Smith's Father Saw the tree of Life 19 Years Before the Book of Mormon was Published](#)," Meridian Magazine, January 7, 2016.
6. Chart of Lehi's dream and Nephi's vision compared. See [Book of Mormon Student Manual](#). Scroll down to "1 Nephi 8:4-35. Vision of the Tree of Life."
7. Monte Shelley, at [LDSGospelDoctrine.net](#)), Monte Shelley GD Lesson Notes. Select 2016 BofM. Select 3) 1 Nephi 8-11, 12:16-18, 15. Select Monte Shelley GD Lesson Notes.
8. "[The Vision of the Tree of Life](#)," BYU Studies Quarterly.
9. "[Lehi's Dream](#)," *Friend*, September 1989. This article contains a sequence of beautiful drawings for children and adults alike.
10. President Marion G. Romney, "[The Book of Mormon](#)," *Ensign*, May 1980, 67).
11. James A. Cullimore (Assistant to the Twelve), "[The Book of Mormon](#)," *Ensign*, May 1976.
12. Stephen H. Webb, "[Mormonism obsessed with Christ](#)," First Things, accessed 1/16/16.

When you read this article by a former evangelical Christian who converted to Catholicism, Ponderize the BKM 3 Quotes: ¶1 And ¶2 with it. Stephen H. Webb is professor of religion and philosophy at Wabash College.

Visit stephenmbird.com> Gospel Doctrine> Lesson 3
"The Vision of the Tree of Life"